laced with coercion or ulterior motives, and truly wants to know and unearth the truth.

When we're able to train ourselves to be curious, we are better able to navigate our circumstances with decreased judgment and less shame. What this means for our finances is increased knowledge of self and ability to bring our spending into alignment with that knowledge. When curiosity is our launching point, we have greater potential to truly understand the inner workings of ourselves and the world around us in a manner that allows us to feel confident about the spending and savings decisions we make.

I use the concept of curiosity very often in my work in the mental health field. Over the years I have engaged with countless individuals ranging in age from eight to eighty-two, each from a variety of backgrounds and each journeying through numerous and varied difficulties. Something nearly everyone (including myself) had in common was judgment toward self. While we are the experts on ourselves, that doesn't mean we always view ourselves entirely accurately. Inevitably we all possess some number of "cognitive distortions," or said more plainly, "unhelpful thinking styles." These can include mindsets like:

Labeling. This is when we sum up ourselves with an overarching statement, like "I'm hopeless" or "I'm just a hot mess." We can adopt these narratives and believe we'll never change. In addition to people referring to themselves as a "spender" or a "saver," we've received countless emails over the years from people saying things like "I've made too many mistakes to recover" or "I'm too old to pay off debt." They're willing to renounce themselves to a subpar life because of a label they accepted as part of their identity.

Overgeneralizing. This is when we identify a pattern based on not enough data. We usually anchor our bias to the first few facts we get about a new topic whether or not those facts are backed up by others or long-term data. Like believing budgeting doesn't work because your first few budgets didn't work or that the stock market is rigged because it happened to be in a bear market when you invested.

Catastrophizing is when we view or think about situations disproportionately, often attributing "terrible," "horrible," "awful" conclusions not congruent with reality. Like the time I got a letter from the IRS saying I still owed all my taxes from the previous year that I *knew* I already paid. I immediately assumed the next thing to show up at my door